Parshas Eikev

Don't Step on the Small Things

Heel Mitzvos · Hashgacha Pratis · Awareness · Unity

I. The Mitzvos We Tread Upon

Parshas Eikev is filled with quiet, powerful messages, and if you will excuse the pun, they should not be stepped on. The very word eikev means heel. Rashi explains that this hints to mitzvos people tend to tread upon with their heels, mitzvos that are easy to forget, that we step over without even thinking, things that seem so small or insignificant that they barely register in our minds.

But why are these heel mitzvos so important? If we think back to last week's parsha, Va'etchanan, we read the Shema, the moment we declare that my will is nothing compared to Hashem's will, and my goal is to be mevatel my own ratzon to His ratzon. If I am truly in that mindset, then who am I to decide which mitzvah matters to Hashem and which one does not? The truth is, Hashem has already told us what matters. He gave us the Torah, the Shulchan Aruch, the Mishnah Berurah, and the wisdom of our sages to guide us. These mitzvos, even the ones that seem small, are part of His plan for us. If they are in the Torah, they matter.

II. Bringing the Small Into Awareness

The real question is: if these mitzvos are so easy to forget, how do we bring them back into conscious awareness? The Baal Shem Tov teaches that hashgacha pratis, individual Divine providence, is revealed in our lives to the degree that we are aware of the small details of our actions. When a Jew trains himself to notice and sanctify even the smallest moments, he opens himself to seeing Hashem's hand everywhere.

I once learned this teaching connected to the mikveh. When preparing to immerse, a chossid asked his Rebbi what kavanos he should have. The Rebbi answered, based on this teaching, that awareness should start before reaching the water itself. As you take off your shoes, think: I am taking off my shoes in preparation for the mikveh. When you remove your socks, think: I am removing my socks in preparation for going into the mikveh. Step

by step, be aware that everything you are doing is part of a holy act. Why? Because, as Hashem said to Moshe Rabbeinu to relay to the Jewish people:

קְדֹשִׁים תִּהְיוּ כִּי קָדוֹשׁ אֲנִי ה׳ אֱלֹקֵיכֶם

"You shall be holy, for I, Hashem your God, am holy."

— Vayikra 19:2

When we learn to pay attention to these small acts, not just the big mitzvos but the little ones, we bring them to the forefront of our minds. They stop being background noise and start being acts of connection to Hashem.

III. Even the Way You Tie Your Shoes

Halacha itself reflects this mindset. The Shulchan Aruch teaches that there is an order for putting on shoes: right shoe first, then left, but tie the left first, as a reminder of the way tefillin are bound on the left arm. Think about that. Something as mundane as putting on your shoes can remind you of the covenant between you and Hashem. This is a perfect example of a heel mitzvah, a small, almost hidden moment that can elevate your day. When I live with that awareness, the little things start to matter more and more. And when they matter to me, Hashem says: if My small things matter to you, then you matter to Me.

IV. The Reward and the Warning

The Torah promises:

וְהָיָה עֵקֶב תִּשְׁמְעוּן… וְשָׁמַר ה׳ אֱלֹקֶיךָ לְךָ אֶת הַבְּרִית וְאֶת הַחֶסֶד

"And it will be, because you will listen to these ordinances and keep them, Hashem your God will keep for you the covenant and the kindness."

— Devarim 7:12–13

But Moshe also warns:

פֶּן תֹּאכַל וְשָׂבָעְתָּ… וְרָם לִבָּבֶךָ וְשָׁכַחְתָּ אֶת ה׳ אֱלֹקֶיךָ

"Lest you eat and be satisfied, and your heart will grow haughty, and you will forget Hashem your God."

— Devarim 8:12–14

The sefarim explain, and we see it plainly in life, that when material blessings increase, there is a spiritual danger. We become distracted, and the small mitzvos are often the first to slip away. When that happens, Hashem may take away the blessing, not necessarily as a punishment, but as a loving reminder to reset, to bring us back to humility and awareness.

V. From the Heel to the Head, Together

Later in the parsha we read Vehaya Im Shamoa, the second paragraph of the Shema. Many of the phrases echo the first paragraph, but there is a key difference: the first speaks in the singular, bechol levavcha, focusing on the individual's relationship with Hashem. The second speaks in the plural, bechol levavchem, addressing the nation as a whole. Rashi comments that bechol levavchem implies the unity of everyone's hearts, where previously the focus was on the individual.

When we learn to value the small mitzvos, we also learn to value the small people, those who might be considered the heels of the nation, recognizing that we all share unified hearts. The head and the heel are both essential to the body. The leaders and the simplest Jews are equally precious to Hashem. When we come together with our hearts, souls, and might united, the blessings of Hashem can be complete.

So the message is simple, but it changes everything: do not step on the little things. Whether it is a small mitzvah, a small person, or a small detail of life, Hashem treasures it all. If it matters to Him, it should matter to us. And when we live that way, we become the people He wants us to be, from the head to the heel.

חזק ואחזק

Shabbat Shalom

Reflection Questions

- *Which mitzvah or good habit do I most often tread on without thinking, simply because it feels too small to register?*
- *What would it look like for me to bring conscious awareness, like the chossid preparing for the mikveh, into one routine part of my day this week?*
- *Where in my life have material blessings made me a little less aware of the Source of those blessings?*
- *Is there someone in my life I have treated as a heel, as small or less significant, when in truth our hearts are meant to be unified?*
- *What is one small, almost hidden practice, like tying the left shoe first, that I could adopt as a regular reminder of my connection to Hashem?*
- *If Hashem's small things matter to me, what would change about how I move through an ordinary day?*